

AI Strategy and Transformation Executive Brief

Board and senior leadership decision guide

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Executive decision

Treat AI strategy as a governed portfolio of institutional decisions, not a list of technology projects. Authorize investment only where mission value, evidence, readiness, ownership and safeguards are credible together.

Why this matters now

- AI demand is rising faster than many institutions can establish data ownership and operating controls.
- Pilots can create recurring cost and vendor dependence without delivering sustained outcomes.
- Public-sector and development settings require traceability, equity, continuity and local capability in addition to model performance.

Five board questions

Question	Evidence expected
What decision improves?	Baseline, beneficiary and outcome measure
Why AI?	Comparison with simpler alternatives
Who is accountable?	Named outcome, data, technical and risk owners
What can stop progression?	Mandatory gates and stopping rules
How will value persist?	Operating budget, capability and exit plan

Portfolio decision model

Score value, feasibility, evidence confidence, urgency and learning value, but keep non-negotiable legal, privacy, safety and human-authority gates separate. A high weighted score cannot compensate for a failed gate.

Recommended 90-day action

Period	Leadership action
Days 1–30	Confirm mandate, decision rights, use-case boundaries and evidence inventory.
Days 31–60	Assess readiness, compare alternatives, score the portfolio and identify remediation.
Days 61–90	Authorize bounded pilots, establish monitoring, capability transfer and decision reviews.

Consulting lessons applied

- Agricultural census modernization shows that definitions, frames and field governance precede analytics.
- Information warehouses show that integration and ownership are institutional—not merely technical—work.
- Results-based monitoring shows that indicators require baselines, sources, review cycles and accountable action.
- Food-loss modelling shows that uncertainty must be translated into consequences and field validation.

Decision gates

Gate	Board test
Mandate	Is the outcome authorized and materially important?
Evidence	Are data, assumptions and limitations documented?
Safeguards	Are legality, privacy, security, equity and human authority adequate?
Operations	Can named teams run, monitor and challenge the system?
Value	Do measured benefits justify total recurring cost and residual risk?

Immediate recommendation

Approve a controlled discovery portfolio rather than enterprise-wide deployment. Require decision records at each gate, finance foundational data and capability work, and stop initiatives that cannot demonstrate sustained institutional value.

Executive takeaway

The strategy is credible when leadership can explain what will be funded, deferred and stopped—and why.